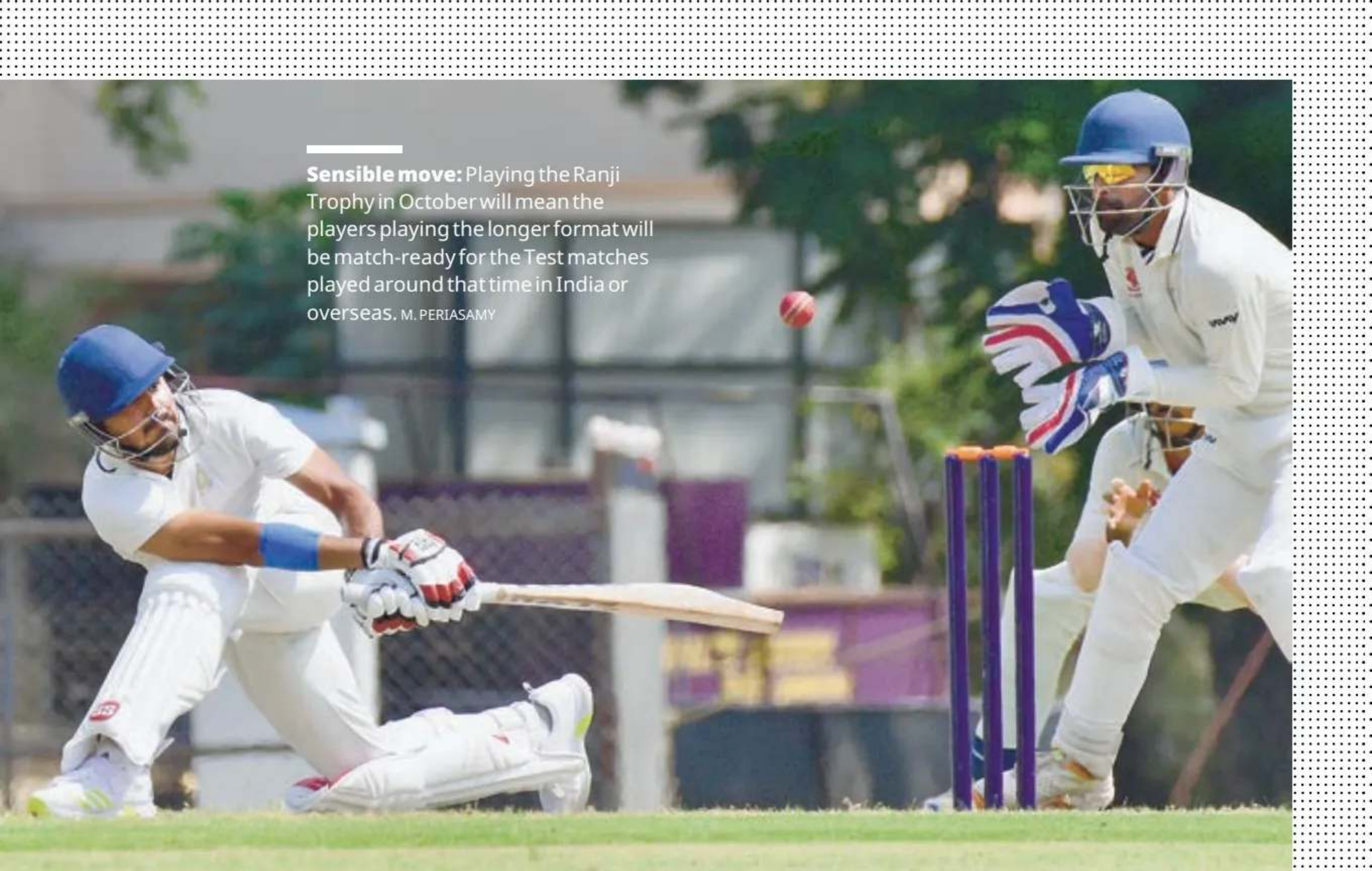




Sensible move: Playing the Ranji Trophy in October will mean the players playing the longer format will be match-ready for the Test matches played around that time in India or overseas. M. PERIASAMY

to play the Ranji Trophy at the start of the season in October and finish by the middle of December. Then play the Vijay Hazare and Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy games, which would also be great match practice for those selected for the various franchises in the IPL.

This way, the national championship, the Ranji Trophy, will get the importance and attention it deserves from those who are giving it a miss to not get injured or stale for the IPL.

Playing the Ranji Trophy in October will also mean the players playing the longer format will be match-ready for the Test matches played around that time in India or overseas.

Playing the Ranji matches with a scheduled start time of 9.30 am is pretty impossible in North India from mid-December to mid-January. This season, some teams have

lost points because their matches didn't start until well after lunch or didn't start at all during this period.

Many years ago, when I was the Chairman of the BCCI Technical Committee, it was decided not to play any games in North India between December 15 and January 15 because of the fog conditions, which made play either delayed or called off for the day.

This year's Ranji season is almost over, with only the semifinals and finals to be played. But maybe for the new season, we could have a different schedule that will see every player keen and raring to play for 'personal reasons'. Those reasons include scoring heaps of runs and capturing plenty of wickets to get picked for the country, which is the highest honour and greatest privilege in the game.

The fact that the BCCI Secretary, Jay Shah, had to send a stern reminder to some of the players to participate in domestic cricket does indicate that maybe some players think that they can do without Indian cricket.